WHOI S2A/ALTO Argo Float Deployment Instructions

We would like to thank you for assisting Woods Hole Oceanographic Institution and the International Argo program in deploying Argo Float for us. We appreciate your time and contributions to the global observing network.

These instructions assume that the floats have been confirmed with WHOI to be started. Do NOT deploy until startup has been confirmed.

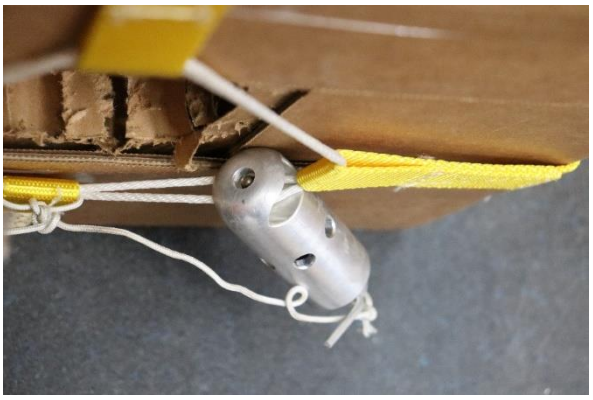
Deploying the floats in a cardboard box with straps and water release.

1. Remove outer plastic sleeve and shrink wrap taking care to not cut the straps. The box is sealed with water-soluble tape and is totally biodegradable. Any stickers on the box are paper based and also biodegradable.



2. Remove the cardboard at the bottom of the box and save it to rest the float on before deployment. See step 6.

3. Check that the water release is still engaged. You should be able to see the top of the pin and that the two loops are around the pin. The water release will look like one of these.





4. Prepare the deployment line by securing the line to the ship.

5. Run the strap loops on to the carabiner and the rope loop on to the carabiner. Lock the carabiner.

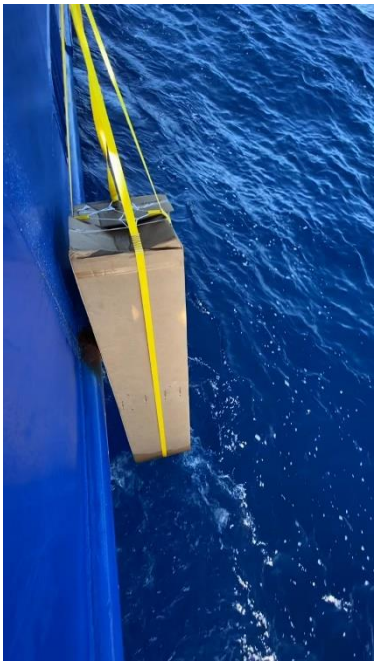


6. Secure the float while waiting for deployment. Rest the float on the carboard to protect the water release and keep the bottom of the float dry.



7. Arrive at the station and get the ‘go ahead’ from the bridge. The ship’s speed should be between 2-5 knots and the float deployed on the lee side

8. Place the float on the rail. Lower the float into the water until just the bottom of the float touches the water keeping the box vertical and allowing the bottom of the box to get wet. The water release should work within 30 seconds. (Lately, we have been having some issues with the water release approximately 25% of the time. If the water release does not work within 30 seconds, please bring the float back on board and deploy using the sling method (see “slingdirection” document). Don’t wait longer than 30 secs as more time doesn’t seem to make a difference, but the cardboard box gets soggy, starts to disintegrate and will be hard to deal with.)



9. Mark the time and position (latitude/longitude) of the deployment. Fill in the launch date, position, time, etc. on the Deployment Log sheet. If it is possible, email the launch information with the float serial number, launch date and position to deploymentinfo@whoi.edu.

10. Please collect the deployment line, the launch harness, and the release mechanism and put them in the deployment supplies box. When you return to port we will supply you with a pre-paid shipping label.